

Set in the valley below the hill, the drystone walls of the Great Enclosure probably served as a palace.

As well as local pottery and ornaments made from copper, bronze, and gold, archaeologists have found many objects of Asian origin, indicating the settlement's prosperity and extensive trade links. These include 13th-century glazed Persian earthenware, 14th-century Chinese dishes, and fragments of painted glass from the Middle East.

In the mid-15th century, however, Great Zimbabwe was abandoned. The end of Great Zimbabwe coincides with the vast conquest by the king of the Karanga, Mutota, who sought to extend his rule over the whole plateau between the Zambezi and Limpopo rivers, including the main gold-bearing areas. But Great Zimbabwe's decline was probably not a result of Mutota's expansion policy. More likely the land could no longer support the concentration of population, forcing many inhabitants to find new areas of woodland where plots could be cleared.

The Mali Empire

In West Africa, the first great empire to be established after the decline of Ghana in the 12th century (see BEFORE) was the Mali. The Mali Empire, like that of Ghana, was based in the Sahel, the savanna region running along the southern border of the Sahara. From the Sahel, it was possible for Mali, like Ghana before it, to exploit the trade across the Sahara to North Africa and control the exchange of gold for salt mined in the desert. The first capital of the Mali

West African terra-cotta head

The artists of Ile-Ife, near Benin in what is now Nigeria, were renowned for naturalistic sculptures of human heads, created to honor rulers they believed were divine.



empire, Niani, was sited by the Bure goldfields on the Niger River, where much of the wealth of the empire originated. Other trade goods included slaves and kola nuts, as well as glass beads and cowrie shells for currency.

Mansa Musa and Timbuktu

The Mali state was founded in 1235 by Sundiata Keita when he united the 12 Mandinke clans of Mali. But it was in the 14th century that the empire reached its peak under Sundiata Keita's grandnephew Mansa Musa (see below).

A devout Muslim, Musa is renowned for his spectacular "Pilgrimage of Gold" to the holy city of Mecca. Musa also extended the boundaries of the Mali Empire, uniting much of the Western Sudan (the huge West African savanna region to the south of the Sahel) under his rule. The Moroccan traveler Ibn Battuta, journeying through Mali in the 1350s, could write that he had enjoyed "complete and general safety" in the area.

During Mansa Musa's reign, the city of Timbuktu on the trans-Saharan trade route to North Africa became a wealthy commercial hub and a great center for scholarship (see right). Musa had the great Jingereber mosque built in Timbuktu; it still stands in the city today. North African and Egyptian scholars visited Musa's court, and he exchanged ambassadors with Egypt, Morocco, and Arabia.

The Songhay

By the early 15th century the Mali Empire was in decline. Subject states began to break away, including the Songhay kingdom, based around the city of Gao about 250 miles (400 km) downriver from Timbuktu. During the 1460s, the Songhay king Sunni Ali took control of much of the Mali Empire, including the city of Timbuktu and the crucial trade routes.

Like the Mali, the Songhay Empire depended for its great wealth on the goldfields on the Niger River and the trans-Saharan trade in salt and slaves. At its height in the 16th century, the Songhay Empire would exceed even that of the Mali in size and wealth.

500 slaves dressed in gold and carrying golden staffs as well as 80 camel-loads of gold accompanied Mansa Musa on his great pilgrimage to Mecca, according to the contemporary Arab historian al-Umari.

HOW WE KNOW

TIMBUKTU LIBRARY

The Sankore Mosque in Timbuktu was one of the most important centers of learning in Africa. Manuscripts preserved at Sankore (such as the one below) document the scholarship and the cultural sophistication of medieval Mali. As one West African proverb states: "Salt comes from the north, gold from the south ... but the treasures of wisdom come from Timbuktu."



AFTER

From the 15th century, Portuguese and other European traders and colonists became ever more involved in African trade and politics.

BENIN

The empire of Benin rose to prominence in West Africa during the 15th century. Benin was well known for **hand-cast bronzes**, which could only be made with royal consent. The first Portuguese traders arrived in about 1485, and a strong political and mercantile alliance was formed. They traded in ivory, palm oil, pepper, and, perhaps most significantly, in **slaves 280–81** >>.



BENIN BRONZE PLATE

THE MUTAPA KINGDOM

Many of the people of Great Zimbabwe settled on the northeastern edge of the Zimbabwean plateau close to the Zambezi River, where they formed the **Mutapa kingdom**. In 1628, the Portuguese replaced the king with a puppet ruler, who later signed a treaty giving the Portuguese free rein to **mine minerals**. This was the first instance of the **Afro-European concession treaties** that would become widespread during the European colonization of Africa **360–61** >>.

KING OF MALI (1312–37)

MANSA MUSA

Mansa Musa was the best known of the Islamic emperors of Mali, largely because of his hajj (pilgrimage) to Cairo and Mecca in 1324–25. He was said to have taken 60,000 porters and hundreds of servants decked in gold. During the trip, Mansa gave away or spent so much gold that it apparently took the economy of North Africa a decade to recover. Musa established sound economic and cultural relations with the countries he traveled through. He brought back with him an Arabic library, religious scholars, and the Muslim architect al-Sahili, who built the great mosques at Gao and Timbuktu.

